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COLUMN: Achieving diversity can be problematic

June 17, 2003 | U-Wire (USA)
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OpenURL Link

(*#_Company_Name_#*) COLLEGE STATION, Texas -- Barring any unforeseen issues, Texas A&M will take a step forward this fall with the installation of the first vice president for institutional diversity. This new position can, and should, bring sweeping changes to the campus. However, the path to diversity at A&M is built on fragile ground -- any misstep in the process will undoubtedly cause more harm than good.

Fortunately, yet somewhat unfortunately, this university has a clean slate to meet the challenges of diversity with. Because this issue is one that has been attacked aggressively only in recent years, failures in the process of diversification have not occurred to such a degree as to hemorrhage the campus community. But, the failures that have occurred at other schools have taken their toll on those campuses, and A&M's leaders must learn from these mistakes.

Fox News recently reported that universities across the United States are increasingly supporting segregated student events, stating that, "Vanderbilt, Stanford University, and the University of California are among those that offer separate graduation ceremonies for minority students. Other schools, including the University of Michigan and University of Pennsylvania, have separate 'celebratory events' for black, Hispanic and Asian-American students." However, graduations are not the only events that have become distorted. Stop Hate on Campus, a student organization at the University of Colorado, held a workshop last month in which white students were not allowed to attend.

Leaders in the field of diversity, such as the co-director of Harvard University's Civil Rights Project, Gary Orfield, believe these actions are not only acceptable but commendable. Is this the new face of "diversity" -- an exclusionary, vile ethos?

Even the poster child for college diversity, The University of California at Berkeley, is facing a crisis on its campus. In UC Berkeley's student newspaper, the Daily Californian, Jesse Gabriel, president of the student government association, offered some harsh criticisms of the current climate at Berkeley.

"UC Berkeley often touts diversity as one of its greatest strengths, but such claims seem empty in the context of the racial polarization that exists on our campus," he said. "While embracing and celebrating one's cultural heritage is one of the most important parts of the college experience ... it is important that students realize that such activities and cross-cultural interactions are not mutually exclusive. In this respect, the Balkanization of our campus is disturbing in that it limits opportunities for learning and for the creation of a larger sense of community on campus."

Is A&M poised to suffer the fate of "Balkanization?"

But just as the various universities' acceptance of these events is a grotesque perversion of anything resembling a diverse campus, so too is the backlash from white students that has resulted. White-only scholarships and graduations are just as troublesome and disheartening to race relations as their minority counterparts are. It is exactly this frustrating polarization, or "Balkanization," that has engulfed universities around the country and could certainly strangle A&M if left unchecked.

These events show that diversity built on the ratios of the populace is merely superficial. The fact that Berkeley, for instance, can have far superior numbers of racial minorities than A&M, yet still have severe racial problems on campus, proves this. Simply increasing minority enrollment at A&M will only enlarge the self-segregated masses, should A&M's culture move in that direction. However, A&M does not have to follow other universities whose paths

to multiculturalism and diversity have degenerated into segregation and squabble.

This university has something rivaled by only a handful of other major colleges around the nation: spirit.

Many A&M students and teachers may believe that this spirit is a trite self-delusion, but no one can deny that this campus is different. For better or for worse, A&M is a very unique academic institution. Campus leaders must build on the camaraderie of being an Aggie. It is from there that celebrating and elucidating the differences among Aggies will be most successful.

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- **Citation (apa Style)**
  Ward, M. (2003, June 17). COLUMN: Achieving diversity can be problematic. *Battalion, The (Texas A&M University) (TX)*. Available from NewsBank: Access World News – Historical and Current: https://infoweb.newsbank.com/apps/news/document-view?p=WORLDNEWS&docref=news/10F6F1F420F1B358.